

Entity Clarity Index

Marketplaces & Platforms

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Executive Summary

Marketplaces exist to be discovered. Most are blocking or failing discovery.

This vertical has the worst clarity profile of any we've analyzed: the highest blocked rate (26%), the lowest High Capability rate (7%), and the highest Low Capability rate (57%). Platforms built on search and discovery are invisible to the new search and discovery layer.

This report applies the Entity Clarity & Capability (ECC) framework to 46 global marketplace and platform companies. What emerges is a sector where AI doesn't merely describe platforms — it decides whether they are necessary at all.

This sector is not about who has the most users. It's about who survives first-pass AI judgment.

Distribution

Posture Distribution

Posture	Count	% of 46	Market Cap
Open	24	52%	~\$3.7T
Defensive	10	22%	~\$155B
Blocked	12	26%	~\$280B

Capability Distribution

Capability	Count	% of 46
High	3	7%
Medium	17	37%

Low

26

57%

Lowest High Capability rate of any vertical (7%) — Most marketplaces cannot be coherently explained by AI

Key Findings

1. The discovery platforms are blocking discovery.

20 of 46 companies are Blocked or have ECC of 0. This includes DoorDash (\$98B), eBay (\$35B), Etsy (\$7B), Expedia (\$22B), Carvana (\$50B), Chewy (\$14B), Upwork (\$2B), and Fiverr (\$1B).

These platforms exist to be found. They have opted out of being found by AI.

2. Access without structure is worse than blocking.

Booking Holdings (\$167B) is open to AI crawling with an ECC of 5. The world's largest online travel company is virtually unreadable. PDD/Temu (\$167B) scores 33. MercadoLibre (\$109B) scores 30.

~\$650B in market cap is accessible but incomprehensible.

3. Entire categories are dark.

Segment	Avg ECCBlocked Rate	
Resale & Specialty	9.9	86%
Travel & Hospitality	24.4	40%
Talent & Services	26.0	67%
eCommerce Marketplaces	35.1	25%
Mobility & Delivery	51.0	25%
Real Estate	51.8	17%

The talent platforms (Upwork, Fiverr) and resale platforms (eBay, Etsy, StockX, RealReal) are almost entirely invisible to AI systems.

4. Infrastructure outperforms consumer-facing platforms.

Company	Type	ECC
Global-e	Cross-border enablement	85
Just Eat Takeaway	Delivery infrastructure	86
Flexport	Logistics	69
Shopify	Merchant enablement	73

The companies that power marketplaces are more legible than the marketplaces themselves.

5. Scale does not predict clarity.

Company	Market Cap	ECC
Amazon	~\$2.46T	64
Booking Holdings	~\$167B	5
PDD/Temu	~\$167B	33
Redfin	~\$1B	81
Just Eat Takeaway	~\$2B	86

The highest-clarity companies are mid-market specialists with focused value propositions. The mega-caps are readable but not authoritative.

Strategic Archetypes

1. Open Traffic Orchestrators

"We accept AI as a traffic allocator."

These platforms allow AI systems to interpret, summarize, and compare them openly. They trade narrative control for continued relevance in AI-mediated discovery.

Examples: Amazon (64), Uber (61), Shopify (73), Trip.com (68), Instacart (75), Alibaba (63), Lyft (66), monday.com (78)

2. Defensive Experience Curators

"We will be seen — but not fully summarized."

These firms permit partial AI access while tightly managing brand, experience, or pricing narratives. They treat AI as a risk surface, not a growth channel.

Examples: Just Eat Takeaway (86), Grab Holdings (75), CarGurus (75), Poshmark (69), Flexport (69), Faire (68), Zillow (66), Wayfair (50), Airbnb (49)

3. Blocked Destination Defenders

"We rely on habit, not interpretation."

These marketplaces actively restrict AI visibility. They assume users will arrive directly — or that regulation and scale will protect them.

Examples: DoorDash, eBay, Etsy, Expedia, Carvana, Chewy, Upwork, Fiverr, MakeMyTrip, Delivery Hero, StockX, RealReal, Revolve, Farfetch, Ozon, Trupanion, Coupang

4. Invisible Enablement Layers

"We power marketplaces — we are not one."

These firms sit behind or alongside marketplaces, enabling cross-border commerce, logistics, pricing, or compliance. They are structurally legible and often outperform consumer-facing platforms in ECC.

Examples: Global-e (85), Redfin (81), Shopify (73), Flexport (69), Faire (68), Whatnot (60)

5. Algorithmically Fragile Intermediaries

"Our value disappears when summarized."

These platforms lose strategic clarity when reduced to an AI explanation. Their business models depend on complexity, arbitrage, or fragmented supply. When AI simplifies them, their differentiation evaporates.

Examples: Booking Holdings (5), PDD/Temu (33), MercadoLibre (30), JD.com (38), Meituan (45), Sea/Shopee (53), Vroom (28), Vipshop (16)

Strategic Implications

AI is becoming the discovery layer for discovery platforms — and ECC determines whether AI frames a marketplace as essential, optional, or obsolete.

Blocking buys time — not immunity.

DoorDash, eBay, Etsy, and Expedia have blocked AI access. This preserves short-term narrative control but excludes them from AI-mediated recommendation. As AI becomes the default research interface, blocking becomes strategic invisibility.

Openness without clarity accelerates commoditization.

Booking Holdings (ECC 5), PDD/Temu (ECC 33), and MercadoLibre (ECC 30) are open but structurally incomprehensible. AI can access them but cannot coherently explain them. This is worse than blocking — it invites misinterpretation while offering no narrative control.

Infrastructure-adjacent players quietly gain trust.

Global-e, Shopify, Flexport, and Faire are more legible than the consumer-facing marketplaces they serve. As AI systems learn to distinguish between platforms and the infrastructure that powers them, enablement layers compound authority.

Entire categories are vulnerable to AI bypass.

When AI cannot coherently recommend any player in a category (talent marketplaces, resale platforms), it may recommend alternatives outside the category entirely — or conclude the category is unnecessary.

The discovery layer is being rewritten. Most marketplaces are not in the new index.

Full Index

Company	Market Cap	Posture	ECC	Archetype
Amazon	~\$2.46T	Open	64	Open Traffic Orchestrator
Alibaba	~\$378B	Open	63	Open Traffic Orchestrator
Shopify	~\$209B	Open	73	Invisible Enablement Layer
Uber	~\$193B	Open	61	Open Traffic Orchestrator
PDD Holdings (Temu)	~\$167B	Open	33	Algorithmically Fragile
Booking Holdings	~\$167B	Open	5	Algorithmically Fragile
MercadoLibre	~\$109B	Open	30	Algorithmically Fragile
DoorDash	~\$98B	Blocked	0	Blocked Destination Defender
Sea Limited (Shopee)	~\$81B	Open	53	Algorithmically Fragile
Meituan	~\$78B	Open	45	Algorithmically Fragile
Airbnb	~\$76B	Defensive	49	Defensive Experience Curator
Coupang	~\$50B	Blocked	0	Blocked Destination Defender
Carvana	~\$50B	Blocked	0	Blocked Destination Defender
Trip.com	~\$47B	Open	68	Open Traffic Orchestrator
JD.com	~\$44B	Open	38	Algorithmically Fragile
eBay	~\$35B	Blocked	0	Blocked Destination Defender
Expedia	~\$22B	Blocked	0	Blocked Destination Defender
Grab Holdings	~\$20B	Defensive	75	Defensive Experience Curator
Zillow	~\$18B	Defensive	66	Defensive Experience Curator
Chewy	~\$14B	Blocked	0	Blocked Destination Defender
monday.com	~\$14B	Open	78	Open Traffic Orchestrator
MakeMyTrip	~\$12B	Blocked	0	Blocked Destination Defender
Faire	~\$12B	Defensive	68	Invisible Enablement Layer
Instacart	~\$11B	Open	75	Open Traffic Orchestrator
Global-e	~\$8B	Open	85	Invisible Enablement Layer
Delivery Hero	~\$8B	Blocked	0	Blocked Destination Defender
Flexport	~\$8B	Defensive	69	Invisible Enablement Layer
Vipshop	~\$8B	Defensive	16	Algorithmically Fragile
Lyft	~\$8B	Open	66	Open Traffic Orchestrator
Wayfair	~\$7B	Defensive	50	Defensive Experience Curator

Etsy	~\$7B	Blocked	0	Blocked Destination Defender
Whatnot	~\$5B	Open	60	Invisible Enablement Layer
Ozon	~\$5B	Blocked	0	Blocked Destination Defender
CarGurus	~\$4B	Defensive	75	Defensive Experience Curator
StockX	~\$4B	Blocked	0	Blocked Destination Defender
Just Eat Takeaway	~\$2B	Defensive	86	Defensive Experience Curator
Upwork	~\$2B	Blocked	0	Blocked Destination Defender
Opendoor	~\$2B	Open	61	Open Traffic Orchestrator
Revolve	~\$2B	Blocked	0	Blocked Destination Defender
Trupanion	~\$2B	Blocked	0	Blocked Destination Defender
Redfin	~\$1B	Open	81	Invisible Enablement Layer
Fiverr	~\$1B	Blocked	0	Blocked Destination Defender
Farfetch	~\$1B	Blocked	0	Blocked Destination Defender
Poshmark	~\$1B	Defensive	69	Defensive Experience Curator
RealReal	~\$500M	Blocked	0	Blocked Destination Defender
Vroom	~\$100M	Open	28	Algorithmically Fragile

Methodology

This analysis applies the Entity Clarity & Capability (ECC) framework to 46 global Marketplaces & Platforms companies, spanning eCommerce, travel, mobility, delivery, real estate, talent, and resale.

ECC evaluates how legible, trustworthy, and structurally interpretable an entity is to modern AI systems across three weighted tiers:

Entity Comprehension & Trust — Narrative coherence, authority signals, interpretability, and trust scaffolding

Structural Data Fidelity — Schema quality, canonical clarity, internal lattice consistency, entity anchoring

Page-Level Hygiene — Technical consistency, crawl efficiency, inference stability, and site-level cleanliness

Each company is classified by AI Posture:

Open — Accessible and legible to AI systems

Defensive — Partially open with controlled narrative exposure

Blocked — Intentionally opaque or inaccessible

Scores reflect strategic positioning, not moral judgment or service quality.